# Toxic Masculinity and the Psyche of Men

**By Mwende "FreeQuency" Katwiwa, Rudy Francisco, and Kyle "Guante" Tran Myhre**

## Yo Masculinity So Fragile
**by Mwende "Freequency" Katwiwa**

Yo masculinity so fragile
it would starve in a house made of kitchens

Yo masculinity so fragile,

it thinks saying you do something like a girl is an insult,

thinks getting a compliment from a man makes him
or you gay,

Yo masculinity so fragile,

that when a woman tells you
*'no'*
you hear
*'try harder',*
but when she tells you she has a man,
you learn to recognize restraint,

4NG Fanatics

so fragile,
it thinks gift wrapping catcalls with compliments
means women should receive them like gifts,
so fragile,
it become a grinch or a gun if they don't.

Yo masculinity so fragile,
it would shatter under the weight of the truth. . .
that it's not helping anyone,
especially yourself,

so fragile,
that if it shatters, it'll still expect a woman
to clean it up off the floor.

Yo masculinity so fragile,
that it can't possibly be all your fault,

so fragile
we must deal with the fact
that this world,
it makes men hard
because it is less complicated
than allowing them to be human.

Yo masculinity is so fragile
that if it shatters
(*and if you are lucky it will eventually shatter*)

it will die a heavy thing,
having consumed so much
of your being.

. . . but on that day,
I look forward
to finally meeting you.

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author:*** ***Mwende "Freequency" Katwiwa***
***Website:*** **https://freequency.medium.com/yo-masculinity-so-fragile-7fbe0b238c59**
***ISBN:*** ***On-line Transcript***
***Publisher:*** ***Freequency.Medium.com***
***Date (Month/Year):*** ***Feb 28, 2018***

## INTRODUCTION

*According to Psychologist Ellen Hendricksen, toxic masculinity can best be described as a narrow, rigid box that men, especially men of color, must contort themselves to fit inside. To do so, he must live by a societal set of beliefs and behaviors:*

1. *Suffer pain in silence.*
2. *Have no needs.*
3. *Never lose.*
4. *Show no emotions other than bravado or rage.*
5. *Show no weakness.*

*If you don't fit in the man box, you pay the price.*

*This needs to stop. We need to be role models for the new generation. We need to teach boys not to be men, but to be human. This is NOT a gender issue. It is a human issue and once we recognize it as such, toxic masculinity will fade.*

*Toxic Masculinity and the Psyche of Men with poems by Mwende "FreeQuency" Katwiwa, Rudy Francisco, and Kyle "Guante" Tran Myhre.*

4NG Fanatics

## Rifle II (aka The Heart and the Fist) by Rudy Francisco (Pg 70-73)

On average
the Mexican government
confiscates approximately
38,000 illegal firearms per year.

In 2012,
Pedro Reyes,
an artist from Mexico City,
convinced his government
to donate the guns to him
so he could turn them into
musical instruments.

So somewhere
there is a tambourine,
a drum set, a guitar,
all made out of things
that were used to take people's lives,
but now they create a sound
that puts life back into people's bodies,

I wonder how long it took to convince
the first rifle that it could hold a note
instead of a bullet, but still fire into a crowd
and make everyone move.

When I was six,
I was taught how to throw a punch,
In the 80s, that was the anti-bullying movement.

The first time one of my classmates
took a yo mama joke a little too far,
I remembered all of my training,
I hit the boy in the face,
I turned his nose into a fountain.

I remember staring at my hands
the same way you stare at a midterm
when all your answers are correct.
I had no idea what class this was
but I did know I was passing
and isn't that what masculinity has become?

A bunch of dudes afraid of their own feelings,
terrified of any emotion other than anger,
yelling at shadows on the wall,
but still haven't realized
that we're the ones standing in front of the light.

We learn how to dodge a jab,
we learn how to step in before we swing,
we learn that the heart is the same size as the fist,

4NG Fanatics

but we keep forgetting they don't have the same functions.
We keep telling each other to man up
when we don't even know what that means.

We turn our boys into bayonets,
point them in the wrong direction,
pull their triggers and fail to acknowledge
all the damage they are doing in the distance.

The word "repurpose"
means to take an object
and give it amnesia.

It means to make something forget what
it's been trained to do so you can
use it for a better reason.

I am learning that this body is not a shotgun.
I am learning that this body is not a pistol.
I am learning that a man is not defined
by what he can destroy.

I am learning that a person
who only knows how to fight
can only communicate in violence
and that shouldn't be anyone's first language.

I am learning that the difference between
a garden and a graveyard is only what
you choose to put in the ground.

One day,
I came across a picture of a strange-looking violin.
The caption said it was made out of a rifle
and I was like,
"someday
that can be me."

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Rudy Francisco***
***Book: Helium (Pg 70-73)***
***ISBN: 978-1943735198***
***Publisher: Button Poetry***
***Date (Month/Year): Nov 2017***

### Ten Responses to the Phrase Man Up
### by Kyle "Guante" Tran Myhre (Clean Version)

1. I know what you're *trying* to say. *Man up* means to *do the difficult thing in the face of hardship,* to *take responsibility.* As if women, and nonbinary people, never faced hardship. As if the people *in my life* who *taught* me responsibility were ever men.

2. You want to question my masculinity, like a schoolyard circle of curses, fine. Just remember: not every problem can be solved by "growing a pair." You can't arm-wrestle your way out of depression. The CEO of the company that just laid you off does not care how much you bench. And I promise, there is no lite beer in the universe full-bodied enough to make you love yourself.

3. Man up? Oh that's that new superhero, right? Mild-mannered supplement salesman Mark Manstrong says the magic words "MAN UP," and then transforms into THE FIVE O'CLOCK SHADOW, the massively-muscled, deep-voiced, leather-duster-wearing super-man who defends the world from, I don't know, feelings.

4. Of course. Why fight to remove our chains, when we can simply compare their lengths? Why step outside the box, when the box has these awesome flame decals on it? We men are cigarettes: dangerous, poisonous, mass-produced.

5. You ever notice how nobody ever says "woman up?" They might imply it, but it's not like a thing people say. Maybe because women and the women's movement figured out a long time ago that being directly ordered around by commercials, magazines, and music is dehumanizing. When will men figure that out?

6. The phrase "Man Up" suggests that competence and perseverance, both generally good things, are also uniquely *masculine*. That women and nonbinary people—not to mention any man who doesn't eat steak, drive a big pickup truck, and have lots of sex *with* women—are nothing more than background characters, comic relief, props. More than anything,

4NG Fanatics

though, it suggests that to be yourself—whether you, wear skinny jeans, rock a little eyeliner, drink some other brand of light beer, or write poetry—will cost you.

7. And how many boys have to kill themselves before this country acknowledges the problem? How many women have to be assaulted? How many trans people have to be murdered? We teach boys how to wear the skin of a man, but we also teach them how to raise that skin like a flag and draw blood for it.

8. Boy babies get blue socks. Girl babies get pink socks. What about green? What about purple? What about orange, yellow, chartreuse, cerulean, black, tie-dyed, buffalo plaid, rainbow…

9. I want to be free, to express myself. Man up. I want to have meaningful, emotional relationships with my brothers. Man up. I want to be weak sometimes. Man up. I want to be strong in a way that isn't about physical power or dominance. Man up. I want to talk to my son about something other than sports. Man up. I want to be who I am. Man up.

10. No.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Kyle "Guante" Tran Myhre***
***Website: https://guante.info/2022/05/31/manup/***
***ISBN: On-line Transcript***
***Publisher: Guante.info***
***Date (Month/Year): May 31, 2011 (Ten Year Anniversary)***

### Chameleon by Rudy Francisco (Pg 46)

As men, it is important that we start asking ourselves,

What will the boys learn from us?

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Rudy Francisco***
***Book: Helium (Pg 46)***
***ISBN: 978-1943735198***
***Publisher: Button Poetry***
***Date (Month/Year): November 2017***

## AWARD HISTORY

***KS State Qualifier (As a Collection)***

****NOTE: Authors are all men of color, perspectives may best be performed by students of color***